sponsored by the division were not delayed for want of underwriting support. Later the bank moved away from its policy of underwriting shares of only those companies whose public issue it managed.

Branch Expansion

We have already noted the ambitious expansion plans of the SBI in the previous Chapter. At the beginning of 1969, a little before Talwar took over as the Chairman, the deficits in the targets of new branches under the two expansion plans were nineteen and sixty respectively. Non-availability of premises continued to be the chief bottleneck. Eventually, thirty-two new branches were opened under the two programmes in 1969, leaving a balance of forty-seven still to be covered.[39]

Since the government did not agree to a scaling down of the target, the deadline for their completion was extended to June 30, 1970. At the end of June 1970, the bank still had to open twenty-four more branches.

The year 1970 saw a quantum jump in the new branches opened with 425 new branches including 246 in rural centres coming up. The 2,000th office of the bank was opened at Kanjhawla near New Delhi in November 1970 by the Finance Minister Y.B. Chavan. Talwar speaking on the occasion observed: 'The banking system today seeks to touch the lives of millions and to subserve the priorities and objectives, as it had never dreamt of doing before. In the process, we regard the opening of the 2,000th office, appropriately enough in the rural setting of Kanjhawla, as but a milestone from which to review the past and contemplate the future.'[40]

Branch expansion continued at a steady pace in 1971 with the opening of 365 offices of which 229 were in areas where there were no banks. The bank had thus opened 790 branches in two years. However, this rapid expansion had placed considerable strain on the manpower resources of the bank and it faced an acute shortage of trained manpower. It was then decided that plans for future expansion would be coordinated in such a manner as to make the organizational strain bearable.[41]

In 1970, the bank set up on an experimental basis, satellite offices, essentially for the mobilization of deposits at places which did not warrant full-time offices but from where deposits could be readily brought into the banking system. By 1972, the bank had opened forty-six such offices in